

Toddler Picky Eating Power Struggle — Action Checklist

PRINT THIS PAGE AND KEEP IT SOMEWHERE VISIBLE

ASSESS BEFORE YOU BEGIN

- ☐ **Check for red flags before starting:** If your child has fewer than 10 accepted foods, gags on textures, or has stopped growing along their curve, ask your pediatrician for a feeding evaluation first so you know whether this guide or clinical support is right for your situation.
- ☐ **Recognize that food refusal is a threat response, not stubbornness:** When your toddler refuses a new food, their brain genuinely reads it as potentially dangerous, which means pushing or pleading will only make avoidance worse by associating food with negative emotions.
- ☐ **Remove all snacking between meals including crackers, juice, and fruit between scheduled meals and snacks so your child arrives at each mealtime genuinely hungry enough to engage with whatever is served without the Division working against you.:** Remove all snacking between meals including crackers, juice, and fruit between scheduled meals and snacks so your child arrives at each mealtime genuinely hungry enough to engage with whatever is served without the Division working against you.
- ☐ **Serve all meals and snacks at the table rather than allowing grazing around the house, and clear all food away between meals to establish a clear structure that teaches your child eating happens only at designated times.:** Serve all meals and snacks at the table rather than allowing grazing around the house, and clear all food away between meals to establish a clear structure that teaches your child eating happens only at designated times.

APPLY DIVISION OF RESPONSIBILITY

- ☐ **Put the same meal on one plate and serve it to everyone at the table, including your child, instead of making separate foods or short-order options that signal some foods are for them and others are not.:** Put the same meal on one plate and serve it to everyone at the table, including your child, instead of making separate foods or short-order options that signal some foods are for them and others are not.
-

- **Stay completely silent during mealtimes about what your child eats or doesn't eat, avoiding comments, descriptions, or pleading, because your silence removes the pressure that prevents them from exploring food on their own terms.:** Stay completely silent during mealtimes about what your child eats or doesn't eat, avoiding comments, descriptions, or pleading, because your silence removes the pressure that prevents them from exploring food on their own terms.

- **Clear the plates calmly at the end of each meal without any commentary about what was eaten or left behind, which reinforces that mealtimes are neutral experiences free from parental judgment or consequence.:** Clear the plates calmly at the end of each meal without any commentary about what was eaten or left behind, which reinforces that mealtimes are neutral experiences free from parental judgment or consequence.

- **Trust the Division even when your child eats nothing:** Your role is to offer adequate, nutritious food at the right times, and your child's role is to decide whether and how much to eat, which means letting go of the urge to intervene.

STRUCTURE MEALTIMES FOR SUCCESS

- **Set consistent meal times like breakfast at 8am, lunch at 12pm, and dinner at 6pm with a small optional snack at 3pm, which establishes predictable hunger cues and lets your child's body rely on scheduled mealtimes for nutrition.:** Set consistent meal times like breakfast at 8am, lunch at 12pm, and dinner at 6pm with a small optional snack at 3pm, which establishes predictable hunger cues and lets your child's body rely on scheduled mealtimes for nutrition.

 - **Allow water freely throughout the day but provide no food between dinner and breakfast, which creates natural hunger cycles that make mealtimes effective without requiring deprivation or force.:** Allow water freely throughout the day but provide no food between dinner and breakfast, which creates natural hunger cycles that make mealtimes effective without requiring deprivation or force.

 - **Offer repeated, low-pressure exposures to new or dropped foods at future meals with no expectation or commentary, because your child's threat response decreases over time when food is consistently presented without consequence or pressure.:** Offer repeated, low-pressure exposures to new or dropped foods at future meals with no expectation or commentary, because your child's threat response decreases over time when food is consistently presented without consequence or pressure.
-

- ☐ **Understand that expanding your child's accepted food list is a slow process measured in weeks and months, not days, and each neutral mealtime exposure teaches their nervous system that the food is safe even when they refuse it initially.:** Understand that expanding your child's accepted food list is a slow process measured in weeks and months, not days, and each neutral mealtime exposure teaches their nervous system that the food is safe even when they refuse it initially.

Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.